

Conformity without Humiliation Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Human Sciences • 20-30 min

Category	Human Sciences	Time	20-30 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	conformity-without-humiliation

Big idea: Consensus can distort judgement.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Conformity without Humiliation Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Conformity without Humiliation Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A low-stakes line-length or preference task with planted majority responses. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Conformity without Humiliation Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Silent voting before and after seeing a group trend. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Conformity without Humiliation Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A norms debrief focused on method and ethics rather than embarrassment. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Consensus can distort judgement.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Conformity without Humiliation Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Conformity without Humiliation Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	Is consensus a reliable guide to truth?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- A low-stakes line-length or preference task with planted majority responses.
- Silent voting before and after seeing a group trend.
- A norms debrief focused on method and ethics rather than embarrassment.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Human Sciences.

Activity Steps

1. Students first make a private estimate.
2. Show a fake or real class average that is clearly high or low.
3. Students make a second estimate.
4. Compare how many shifted towards the group. Debrief immediately.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Is consensus a reliable guide to truth?
- When does shared knowledge become groupthink?
- How can communities improve or distort individual knowledge?

Knowledge Questions

- Is consensus a reliable guide to truth?
- When does shared knowledge become groupthink?
- How can communities improve or distort individual knowledge?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with a low-stakes line-length or preference task with planted majority responses. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...